

ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

How Not To Succeed

He may be a great golfer but he doesn't know how to be a man. In all the revelations about Tiger Woods, perhaps this was the most telling from one of his 10 (or is it 11?) mistresses. Not just about the world's best golfer but about how we define success. Chase excellence, success will follow, says a forthcoming film, *3 Idiots*, the strongest cinematic indictment yet on how we are creating an army of robots. In last week's *Rocket Singh: Salesman of the Year*, Ranbir Kapoor berates his hard working, God-fearing grandfather in disgust, "*Aapne choron wale kaam hi nahin sikhaye* (you didn't teach me thievery)". It's a sad commentary on our times that children, even fictional ones, think they need duplicity to get ahead in life. That old-fashioned virtues that built behemoths and erected empires are no longer valued or needed. That success, no matter how it is achieved, is what matters. Define it in percentages (98.3 per cent which gets you into a good college in Delhi) or in money (a Rs 12 lakh starting salary from an MNC for a fresh graduate). And ignore at your peril the cost to your children. In our quest to create the perfect future producers, we have forgotten how to craft good character. We have forgotten to prepare them for failure. Not every child is born a genius and most never become one. Malcolm Gladwell's fascinating new collection of articles, *What the Dog Saw*, gives the example of the artist Cezanne who discovered his true style in his sixties and of the writer Ben Fountain who wrote his first best-selling book at the age of 48. But neither Cezanne's patrons nor Fountain's wife gave up on them. By all accounts in contemporary, cut-throat India, they would have been declared failures.

More than a study in adultery, Tiger's is a cautionary tale about moulding a child, especially one with prodigious talent—his father Earl, who served in Vietnam, introduced Tiger to golf at nine months, and put him on *The Mike Douglas Show* at the age of two, playing with Bob Hope. He created a legend who won 46 major championships in his first 10 seasons on the tour but forgot to teach him how to respect women, be a good father and certainly be a loyal son. In our race to focus young minds on maths tuitions and piano lessons, take Class 12 board exams and clear CAT, we forget to equip them with more valuable skills. How to accept failure and overcome it; how to experience life and learn from it; how to be the best one can. It's something that parents have forgotten so how can we expect our children to know? Eric Hanushek of Stanford estimates that students of a very bad teacher learn a year's worth less than children of a very good teacher. Given that all parents are teachers in their day-night jobs, that should be a sobering statistic.



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WON: By boxer **Suranjay Singh**, the gold medal at the AIBA President's Cup in Baku, Azerbaijan, beating Nordine Oubaali of France in the fly-weight (51 kg) category.

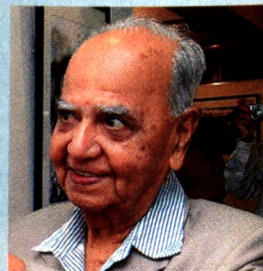
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WON: By the India Under-23 team, the South Asian Football Federation (SAFF) Cup in Dhaka, beating defending champions the Maldives. This was India's fifth SAFF Cup win.

APPOINTED: Bihar Governor **Devanand Konwar** as the governor of West Bengal. He will hold both charges till a governor is named for West Bengal following Gopalkrishna Gandhi's retirement.

DIED: **T.S. Satyan**, one of India's first photojournalists. He started his career in 1948 with the *Deccan Herald*. He was 85.



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